08

GIVING AND LEGACY

You learned the 8 levels of Rambam in 8th grade. The gap between what you believe about tzedakah and how you actually give is the entire content of this class.

CK ACADEMY

A COLLECTIVE KINDNESS INITIATIVE

01 READ THIS FIRST

You already know this.

You learned Rambam's 8 levels in 8th grade. You can quote chapter and verse on tzedek vs tzedakah, on dignity, on the highest level being self-sufficiency.

Now answer this honestly: what percentage of your income did you give last year? If you don't know the number, that's the answer. If you do know, was it under 10%? Was it on autopay or in clumps? Was it last-in-the-month leftover, or first-out?

By Sunday night, you'll have set up an automatic recurring transfer for tzedakah, fired on the 1st, every month, no matter what. The lesson is in the setup.

WHAT THIS CLASS IS NOT

Not a recap of Rambam. Not a debate about ma'aser percentage. Not a lecture on which causes deserve your money. This is the page that ends with you having a recurring monthly transfer set up before you sleep tonight.

02 THE MIRROR

12 months. Real numbers.

WRITE THE NUMBERS FROM YOUR OWN LIFE

Pull last 12 months of bank statements. Count every check, every Venmo, every shul appeal, every school pledge. The number will surprise you. People who give intentionally know their number cold.

1. Total income (after tax) last 12 months	$ _____
2. Total tzedakah given (every check, every Venmo, every appeal)	$ _____
3. Tzedakah as % of income	____ %
4. Was it on autopay (A) or in clumps (C)?	_____
5. Did the giving feel intentional or reactive?	_____

If you couldn't answer row 2 within 5 minutes, your giving is reactive, not intentional. If row 4 is C and row 5 is reactive, this class is the entire fix. The rule below makes intentional automatic.

03 WHY THIS GAP EXISTS

Give first. Or never.

Most frum couples give last. After bills, after groceries, after the kids' shoes, after Yom Tov, what's left goes to tzedakah. By design, what's left is usually nothing or near it.

Tzedek means justice. The resources weren't fully yours to begin with. When you give to someone in need, you're not being generous; you're returning what was already designated for them. The posture isn't "I'm being kind," it's "I'm doing my job."

Reverse the order. Tzedakah comes out FIRST, on the 1st of the month, automated. Whatever's left after giving is what you have to live on.

GIVE LAST

WHAT MOST DO

ORDER
Bills, food, lifestyle, then maybe give

AMOUNT
Whatever's left

RELIABILITY
Inconsistent

AVG %
3-6%

GIVE FIRST

WHAT WORKS

ORDER
Tzedakah on 1st, then everything else

AMOUNT
Pre-decided %

RELIABILITY
100%

AVG %
10%+

> **If giving comes last, there's never anything left. The order isn't a preference, it's the only structure that works.**

04 THE RULE THAT ENDS THE GAP

The rule.

TZEDAKAH ON THE 1ST

Tzedakah goes out on the 1st of the month. Automated. Anything else is theatre. If you can't decide the recipient yet, send to a donor-advised fund and decide later. The transfer is the lesson, not the recipient choice.

How to set this up tonight

Open your bank's bill-pay or recurring transfer screen. Set up: 10% of monthly take-home, fires on the 1st, recipient is either your shul, a specific tzedakah org, or a donor-advised fund (Fidelity Charitable or Vanguard Charitable, $0 minimum, you decide recipients later).

If you don't know your monthly take-home cold, set it to a flat dollar amount based on a conservative estimate. $300/month is more than zero/month. You can adjust upward when you have better data.

Donor-advised funds are the cheat code. You contribute to your own "fund," get the tax deduction immediately, then grant to specific causes any time. No deciding-the-recipient bottleneck.

05 WHERE THIS FAILS

Just this month.

The autopay isn't where this fails. The cancel-button is where it fails. Three months in, a tough week comes, and the autopay looks pause-able. Don't.

TRAP 1 / 'I'LL CANCEL JUST THIS MONTH'

A tough month comes. Tuition spike, car repair, simcha. The autopay looks negotiable. **Once you pause it, you've broken the structure.** The whole point of automation is removing the decision from a moment of weakness. Pre-commit now: this transfer doesn't pause. Find the money elsewhere.

TRAP 2 / 'I'LL GIVE MORE WHEN I'M WEALTHY'

The myth that you'll suddenly become generous at $250K HHI. **You won't.** By then you've spent 20 years training your reflexes around scarcity, hoarding, and self-justification. People who learn to give at $60K HHI know how to handle wealth when it arrives. People who don't, never do.

TRAP 3 / KIDS NEVER SEE THE DECISION

If your kids only see your tzedakah as a once-a-year thing or as something Tatty handles privately, they'll inherit the same pattern. **Bring them into the decision.** When the family is allocating, ask their input. Real input. Not lip service.

TRAP 4 / THE SHUL APPEAL AS SUBSTITUTE

Year-end you write a $2,000 shul appeal check and feel like you've given. **One reactive donation is not a giving system.** Appeal donations are fine, on top of the 10% structural giving, not instead of it. Most people use them as instead.

06 THE ACTION

TONIGHT, BEFORE SLEEP

Do this. Now.

This is the only class where the deadline is tonight, not Sunday. Setting up a recurring transfer takes 8 minutes. Putting it off until Sunday is exactly the pattern this class breaks.

01 **Open your bank's recurring transfer or bill-pay screen.** Set up: 10% of monthly take-home, fires on the 1st of every month.

If your spouse needs to be in the loop, do this together. If you don't know exact take-home yet, use a flat dollar estimate. Adjust later.

02 **Pick the recipient.** Donor-advised fund (Fidelity Charitable or Vanguard Charitable, both $0 minimum), your shul's general fund, or one specific tzedakah org. If you can't decide, default to donor-advised. Decide specific recipients later from inside the fund.

The deciding-the-recipient delay is the most common reason this autopay never gets set up. Pick something tonight.

03 **Confirm the transfer is recurring, not one-time.** Look at the confirmation screen. Verify it says "recurring" or "every month." Check the date is the 1st.

One-time transfers are not the action of this class. The recurring schedule is the structure.

04 **Screenshot the confirmation.** Text spouse: "Class 08 done. Tzedakah autopay live, 1st of month, $X to [recipient]."

If you can't show your spouse the screenshot tonight, the transfer doesn't exist yet.

PROOF OF COMPLETION

Screenshot of confirmed recurring monthly tzedakah transfer (amount, date, recipient visible). Sent to spouse tonight with the words "Class 08 done." Cannot wait until Sunday.

07 THE CONVERSATION

Tonight. With your spouse.

RULES

30 minutes. Phone away. The giving conversation often turns into a values conversation. Stay on numbers and structure first. Values clarify when the structure is in place.

01 Each of you: what % of last year's income did we give? Compare to what we believed we gave. Gap?

Most couples have given less than they think and don't know.

02 What's the cause neither of us has supported despite agreeing it's important? Why have we avoided it?

Honest answer: usually the cause feels too big, or the recipient feels distant.

03 If our kids only learned about tzedakah from watching us, what would they be learning?

Pattern recognition. They'll inherit your actual behavior, not your stated values.

04 When we're 60, looking back, what's the giving legacy we want to have built?

Specific. "More giving" isn't a legacy; an endowment, a yeshiva building fund, a scholarship is.

05 Tonight, before sleep, who is setting up the autopay and what's the amount?

Pick one. Sign the contract.

SECTION TWO

Test.

10 questions. None of these can be answered from memory of the lesson. You'll need real numbers from your own life.

08 THE TEST

Test.

Each question requires real numbers, real names, or real decisions from your life. Do the work. Skipping defeats the point.

1. NUMBERS **Pull last 12 months of bank statements. Calculate total tzedakah given, total income, and percentage. Don't estimate. List the 3 largest individual contributions and what each was for.**

2. DECISION **Pick the recipient for your monthly tzedakah autopay. Donor-advised fund? Specific shul? Specific org? If donor-advised, which one (Fidelity Charitable, Vanguard Charitable)? Why this one?**

3. ACTION **Screenshot or describe in writing the recurring transfer you set up tonight: amount, day of month, recipient, account it pulls from. Tape the screenshot here.**

4. TRAP TEST **Three months from now, tuition payment is bigger than expected and money is tight. The tzedakah autopay looks pause-able. What's your written rule? What do you actually do?**

5. REAL LIFE **Find one frum family known for serious giving. Without naming them: what's their giving structure? Recurring or reactive? What do they say about it? Three specifics.**

08 THE TEST, CONTINUED

6. DECISION How will you bring your kids into the giving decision? Specific: at what frequency, what level of input, at what age? Write the structure.

7. NUMBERS If you give 10% consistently from age 30 to age 65 with 4% income growth annually, calculate the rough total amount given over the lifetime. Show the math.

8. TRAP TEST Year-end shul appeal arrives. You feel pressure to give $2,500. You haven't built the autopay yet. What do you do tonight? What changes for next year?

9. REAL LIFE List the three causes you've supported in the last 12 months. For each, write what they actually do, in one sentence, without looking it up. If you can't, what does that say about how you currently give?

10. ACTION Write the text message you'll send your spouse tonight confirming the tzedakah autopay is live. Must include amount, date, recipient. Sendable as written.

09 WHAT A STRONG ANSWER LOOKS LIKE

Reference.

These aren't right answers. They're examples of strong answers, written with real specificity. If yours are vaguer than these, redo them.

1. Strong: "Income $112,000. Tzedakah $5,800 = 5.2%. Largest 3: shul appeal $2,000, brother-in-law's mosad $1,500, year-end Chai Lifeline $800. Most was reactive." Weak: "I think we gave around 8% to various places." Specifics or you didn't pull the data.

2. Strong: "Vanguard Charitable donor-advised fund. $0 minimum, $250 minimum grant, low fees, gives me flexibility to decide recipients monthly. Setting up $400/month transfer." Weak: "I'll figure out the recipient later."

3. Either screenshot taped here, or detailed written confirmation: "Set up at Chase, $400/mo, 1st of each month, recurring transfer to Vanguard Charitable account # ___. Confirmation # ABC123." Vague answers fail.

4. Strong: "Written rule: tzedakah autopay does not pause. If money is tight, the cut comes from a discretionary category (dining, clothing). The order doesn't reverse. If genuinely impossible one month, I find a different category to cut, not tzedakah."

5. Strong: "Family I know gives 15-20% via standing monthly transfer to a donor-advised fund. They pick specific causes 4x/year as a couple. They say: started at 5% in their 20s, raised 1% per year. Said the autopay was the unlock."

6. Strong: "Monthly family meeting (15 minutes), kids see the giving budget, weigh in on causes. Younger kids (5-9) pick a small portion ($25 monthly to a cause they choose). Older kids (10+) research and present options. Real input, not lip service."

7. Strong: "$110K income at 30, growing 4%/year to age 65 = lifetime income roughly $7.5M. 10% = $750,000 given over the lifetime. That's a 35-year endowment of someone else's family."

8. Strong: "Tonight: set up the autopay first ($400/month, 1st), THEN write the shul appeal check separately as additional. Do not pretend the shul appeal IS the giving structure. Year-end appeals are on top of structural giving, not instead."

9. Strong: "Three causes: (1) Chai Lifeline, supports families with children facing serious illness through camps and counseling. (2) The Shliach in Springfield, runs an outreach center and Hebrew school. (3) Local mosad, food packages for needy families weekly. If I couldn't describe what they actually do, my giving is a check-writing reflex, not informed support. The fix is reading their last annual report before the next contribution."

10. Strong: "Sara, set up tzedakah autopay at Chase. $400/month, fires on the 1st, going to Vanguard Charitable account. Class 08 done." Sendable. Has all required elements.